

The Chavín of South America

To the South, the Peruvian Chavín culture began to develop in the Andes region around 1000 BCE, and then spread along a great strip of the Peruvian coast. The major excavated site associated with Chavín culture is that of Chavín de Huántar, high in the Andes, almost 185 miles (300 km) north of Lima.

Chavín de Huántar may or may not have been the center or birthplace of the culture, but it was certainly of great importance. At the heart of this sizable settlement, which could have been home to around 3,000 people, was a monumental ceremonial complex made of stone blocks and decorated with impressive relief carving.

As in Olmec culture, Chavín art often shows figures combining both human and animal features. At the center of the Old Temple at Chavín de Huántar is a sculpture showing the great Chavín



Chavín jaguar imagery

Several well-preserved panels depicting jaguars—important in Andean culture as well as Mesoamerican—have been found at Chavín de Huántar. They would have surrounded the impressive main plaza of this ancient site.

god, El Lanzon, with a human body, a catlike head, and serpentine hair. Such depictions may be “transformation” images associated with religious ritual, perhaps signifying that priests could transform themselves into deities.

The buildings and site at Chavín de Huántar reveal the great engineering and architectural expertise of peoples in this part of the world, especially in the face of difficult terrain. Flat terracing had to be created to build the Old Temple, just as the Olmecs had to reshape the plateau at San Lorenzo, and the later Zapotecs would master the ultimate challenge of building Monte Albán (see p.140) on top of an artificially leveled mountain.

Olmec ritual

These small jade figures and upright artifacts are Olmec finds from La Venta. The figures have the part-human, part-feline features of the were-jaguar. The scene probably represents some kind of sacred ritual, with the artifacts being votive objects.

Different but often closely related cultures wove themselves into a complex web—rising, fading out, existing simultaneously, or persisting in some places more than others.

FROM OLMECS TO ZAPOTECs

Olmec culture had **peaked** by 600–400 BCE, but its **influence** was strongly felt in various **regional cultures** that persisted afterward throughout Mesoamerica, specifically the **Zapotecs** at **Monte Albán 142–43** >>, in the Oaxaca Valley of southeastern Mexico.

THE BIRTH OF MAYA CIVILIZATION

Maya culture **140–41** >> arose from **Native American** settlements in Mexico’s Yucatán Peninsula and Central America. Significant **early developments** were taking place in the 600s or 500s BCE, and the culture had **really established** itself by around 200 BCE.

SOUTH AMERICAN CULTURES

While **Chavín culture** was declining by c. 200 BCE, other cultures (such as those of the **Paracas** and **Nazca** in Peru) were flourishing. Although regional in nature, they often had similar characteristics.

JAGUAR IMAGERY

The **jaguar** remained important to the **Maya culture**, and also to the much later **Aztecs**.

